

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

against both Kashmiri leaders and the Indian state in December 1989 when Mufti's daughter Rubaiya Sayeed was kidnapped by JKLF militants, who demanded the release of five of their men in exchange for her freedom. Farooq was against any negotiations with the terrorists while the Mufti, according to one source, was desperate to strike a deal even though intelligence agencies assured him that the militants were highly unlikely to harm his daughter. Farooq was overruled, the five JKLF militants were released and Rubaiya was freed. That a weak-kneed government had buckled in the face of terrorist demands encouraged the militants and their backer to go in for the kill. A.S. Dulat, head of the Intelligence Bureau for Kashmir at the time, says, "On December 13, when their compatriots were released, these groups in the Valley celebrated by bursting crackers. They began to believe that everything was possible now, including *azadi*."

WHY DID PANDITS BECOME THE PRIMARY TARGETS?

There were other factors fuelling the insurgency. Pakistan-backed jihadists in Afghanistan had forced the Soviets to withdraw troops and leave the country. Simultaneously, unknown to many, Pakistan, with the help of China and North Korea, had developed a weaponised nuclear capability in 1989. That gave the country the freedom to launch a covert, subterranean war against India, armed with the knowledge that, even if provoked, New Delhi would hesitate to launch a full-scale conventional war to avert a nuclear conflagration. A third factor was the increasing support for extremists among Muslims in the Valley following the political intrigues and poor governance in the state. Pandits became the primary target only because they could be easily terrorised, and a wave of attacks on a few of them would force them to flee the Valley. Pakistan-backed militant groups could then be left to create mayhem and declare the Valley's independence from India. Or so they thought.

With the law and order situation worsening, Singh and Mufti decided they would bring Jagmohan back as governor. Farooq said he would resign if that happened, but Singh went ahead anyway. Farooq put in his papers and Jagmohan was sworn in as governor on January 19, 1990. By then, Srinagar was already burning. Jihadists were taking out processions chanting slogans such as '*Raliv, galiv ya chaliv* (Convert, face death or flee)' against the Pandits. Meanwhile, Jagmohan ordered a crackdown by security forces that included search and seize operations, increasing citizens' resentment against the government. All hell, however, broke loose on January 21, when security forces opened fire on protesters in Gawkadal in downtown Srinagar, killing at least 50 people. Now the Kashmiri Muslim was truly inflamed.